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- **Jul. 2023:** The period for filing objections and suggestions ends. The government to start hearing anytime now
- **Jun. 2023:** The state government makes modifications in the draft and invites objections and suggestions on the changes made
- **Feb. 2021:** The Town and Country Planning Department submits a report with objections and suggestions to the government. The matter is back on the backburner
- **Jun. 2020:** The draft is reissued after the first wave of the Covid pandemic, and objections and suggestions are heard

commercial activity was not envisaged. Over the years, a cabal of planners in the government and Bhopal Municipal Corporation (BMC), administrators and politicians have allowed rampant commercialisation of the residential areas. This has led to severe parking crises and traffic snarls. "Whenever the new Master Plan is notified, all issues of commercialisation in residential areas will be looked into," state urban administration minister Bhupendra Singh told INDIA TODAY.

Resident Welfare Associations have been complaining about the issue, but to no avail. A key reason for all the lethargy: several politicians and administrators are invested in these commercial properties. That's why local politicians have been supporting commercialisation, on the grounds that the people want greater monetary returns from their properties. Action, therefore, has been sporadic—and futile. In 2022, the BMC sealed a Lotus Electronics outlet in E1 sector and a FabIndia outlet in E2 sector of Arera Colony, but both claim they have got a court stay. "Despite our efforts, property and construction remain one of the biggest sinks for black money. The modus operandi is to secure a loan, buy a house, dismantle it, reconstruct it lavishly and give it on commercial rent," says a top income tax official.

Contrary impulses among—even within—official agencies add to the anarchy. The BMC, whose job is to demolish illegal structures, also helps itself to commercial property tax from them while the power distribution company extends commercial connections. "The BMC is cash-strapped and since there is no clearance from the top to stop commercialisation, we feel we might as well collect commercial rent from these structures," says outgoing BMC commissioner V.S. Choudhary Kolsani. But he concedes the lack of direction is spoiling the "beautiful city planned by our predecessors".

There's an ecological end to the story too. The draft plan has imposed restrictions on constructions around Kerwan, a reserve forest on the city's outskirts that has over half a dozen tigers. The animals visit the peripheral zones, contiguous with a forest corridor linking to the Ratapani sanctuary. Again, top politicians and bureaucrats own land in this area and are upset at the proposal. Equally upset are a set of IAS and IPS officers who have invested in a residential project where the floor area ratio (FAR) has been reduced from 0.75 to 0.06 in the draft. FAR signifies the area on which construction can be done as a percentage of the total area of the plot. The government claims the FAR in this area, not very far from the National Judicial Academy, was always 0.06 but was increased at the behest of these officers and the 'mistake' has been reversed.

The pressure on the government is so much that even a ruling party MLA from Bhopal, Rameshwar Sharma, has objected to the changes in the draft. The last date for submission of objections and suggestions was July 2, but the hearing has not even begun yet. No wonder, city residents are worried the government has capitulated under pressure yet again. Bhopal's deliverance is still a few milestones away. ■